# Cybersecurity: Cyber impact of conflict in the Middle East, and other cybersecurity news

World Economic Forum - Full Verbatim Text Analysis

Published: Mar 17, 2026

## Guía de Estudio de Ciberseguridad

- Resaltado Azul: **Active Voice** (Indica quién realiza el ataque o la acción).
- Resaltado Amarillo: **Passive Voice** (Indica qué sistema o infraestructura fue afectada).

---

## Metadata

**Published:** Mar 17, 2026 · **Updated:** Mar 17, 2026
**Author:** Akshay Joshi, Head of the Centre for Cybersecurity, World Economic Forum.
**Source:** https://www.weforum.org/stories/2026/03/cyber-impact-conflict-middle-east-other-cybersecurity news-march-2026/

- This regular round-up brings you key cybersecurity stories from the past month.
- Top cybersecurity news: Cyber plays key role in Middle East conflict; misuse of AI for cybercrime; Portuguese officials' messaging accounts targeted.
- The World Economic Forum's Centre for Cybersecurity provides an independent and impartial platform to reinforce the importance of cybersecurity as a strategic imperative.

## 1 Cyber impact of conflict in the Middle East

The escalation in the Middle East over the past few weeks **has highlighted** the growing role of cyber warfare in modern conflicts. While military strikes **are widely reported**, in the background, cyber operations **are more quietly taking place**.

The impacts **extend** far beyond the regions directly involved in the conflict, with Europol spokesperson Jan Op Gen Oorth saying he **expects** to see more cyberattacks against European infrastructure and an increase in online fraud, exploiting the flurry of information circulating about the conflict online, Reuters reports.

**Here are some of the reported cyber impacts of the conflict:**

- **Surveillance networks created:** The Financial Times **was told** that CCTV and traffic cameras **had been hacked** to create a surveillance network ahead of military strikes.

- **Websites and apps hacked:** Multiple news websites and the BadeSaba app, a religious calendar app, **have been hacked** to display messages.

- **Medical device company targeted:** Iran-linked hackers reportedly **seized** company data from Stryker, one of the world's largest medical device companies. The organization **stated**: "We **have** no indication of ransomware or malware and **believe** the incident **is contained**."

What comes next is unclear, though Adam Meyers, senior vice president of counter adversary operations with CrowdStrike, **suggested** to Reuters that the current cyber activity **may precede** more aggressive operations: "CrowdStrike **is already seeing** activity consistent with Iranian-aligned threat actors and hacktivist groups conducting reconnaissance and initiating DDoS attacks."

Earlier this year, the World Economic Forum's Global Cybersecurity Outlook 2026 **highlighted** the significant impact that geopolitical risk has on cybersecurity. The report **found** that 64% of organizations **are accounting for** geopolitically motivated cyberattacks such as disruption of critical infrastructure, sabotage or espionage.

## 2 Misuse of AI for cybercrime

Rapid developments in artificial intelligence (AI) **are accelerating** innovation across sectors. However, just as these capabilities **are opening** new possibilities for systems that **benefit** people, society and the environment, they also **present** cyber risks.

To help address this and improve transparency within the sector, big tech companies **are sharing** regular analyses of how bad actors are using AI tools for malicious purposes.

**Here are some of the reported use cases of AI for cybercrime:**

- **Automating scams:** OpenAI's recently published threat report **highlighted** instances of romance scams targeting Indonesian men and another targeting fraud victims, impersonating law enforcement to **defraud** these victims further.

- **Influence operations:** The report also **revealed** large-scale social media influence campaigns that **use** AI to generate content and distribute it via social platforms.

- **Creating code:** Anthropic's Threat Intelligence report **stated** that a UK-based criminal with minimal coding skills **used** Claude to build and sell ransomware packages online for up to $1,200, outsourcing the technical expertise entirely to AI.

- **Infiltrating organizations:** Both Anthropic and Google's Gemini **referenced** North Korean actors using AI models to build false CVs and pass job interviews, to earn salaries with little work or **place** undercover IT workers at key companies.

Moreover, a new report from INTERPOL **found** that AI-enhanced fraud **is** 4.5 times **more profitable** than traditional methods. Agentic AI systems, the report **notes**, **can autonomously plan and execute** complete fraud campaigns from reconnaissance to ransom demands.

"**Enabled** by artificial intelligence, low-cost digital tools and increased global criminal collaboration, we **are witnessing** the industrialization of fraud," INTERPOL Secretary General Valdecy Urquiza said in a statement.

The report **was released** during the Global Fraud Summit, which **is being held** in Vienna and **was organized** by INTERPOL and the UN Office on Drugs and Crime.

## 3 News in brief: Top cybersecurity stories this month

**Portuguese officials' messaging accounts targeted:** Portugal's national intelligence service **has warned** that hackers are running a global campaign to access WhatsApp and Signal accounts of government officials, diplomats and military personnel. The actors **are tricking** users into sharing passwords to access private chats. See how Signal responded to this incident below:

**Customer data leaked in telecom hack:** The criminal group behind a recent hack on Dutch telecom provider Odido **has published** customer information on the dark web. Personal data for around 6 million customers **was stolen**, including names, telephone numbers, e-mail addresses, bank account numbers, birth dates and passport numbers.

**Sweden warns energy sector to raise security:** The nation's security agency **warned** the energy sector to heighten its defences following a recent cyberattack in Poland, though no specific threat exists for Swedish infrastructure. The alert **aims** to make Sweden a harder target, with authorities requesting upgraded security measures.

## 4 More about cybersecurity on Forum Stories

**Why quantum security is a question leaders cannot ignore right now.** Quantum computing **is not yet breaking** encryption, but the risk is live. The "harvest now, decrypt later" model **means** adversaries **can capture** encrypted data today and **unlock** it once quantum capabilities mature. In 2024, the US NIST **finalized** its first post-quantum cryptography standards, signalling the transition **is** no longer theoretical. Yet many organizations **remain** unprepared. Migration is a multi-year programme spanning hardware, software, protocols and supply chains, especially where systems **last** decades. Leaders **must align** three timelines: how long data **must stay** secure, how long migration **will take** and when quantum capability **arrives**. Find out why quantum security **is** now a governance issue.

**Is this how to prepare for an agentic AI-driven future?** Agentic AI **marks** a real shift in how work **gets done** inside an enterprise. We're **moving** beyond systems that assist humans to systems that **are trusted to reason, decide and act** on their own. That change **is** already underway and it's **happening** inside core business workflows – not in labs or pilot programmes. An expert **breaks down** how to prepare for an agentic AI-driven future.

**How to prioritize cyber resilience in the healthcare sector.** Healthcare organizations **face** a growing paradox: prioritizing patient care and digital innovation often **leaves** cyber resilience underfunded, yet cyber incidents increasingly **disrupt** care delivery and patient safety. However, strategic digital twin simulations **can help** leaders test investment choices, **reveal** hidden trade-offs and **identify** counterintuitive strategies that **improve** clinical capacity and digital resilience simultaneously. Read how data-driven decision tools **can strengthen** governance and **protect** patient outcomes.